

Trust in Security

What is it about screensavers that gets a million unsuspecting people clicking on a worm every time? Every year brings new e-mail worms that are the fastest ever and the largest ever, yet they all use the same simple social-engineering trick. They exploit trust. If you are in someone's address book, you are likely to have trusted relationship with them. Thanks very much for the screensaver, friend.

Why should you care, or even need to know about updates? They should just happen in the background, without any need to know at all. There is already too much complexity to deal with; no point in adding another decision-making to the loop, when you can't really make an informed decision. How do you know how severe a flaw in your OS is? Every flaw is severe, if you are connected to the Internet.

Anti-virus and firewall software let you update automatically. And users understand why they need to do so, see the importance of that need, and let them get on with their business. An OS update, on the other hand, means that you have to choose with trepidation, from a list of updates presented to you.

The update for the critical flaw that knocked Windowsupdate.com off the Internet was around for weeks before the attack occurred. Why did users choose not to update their Windows? How does lack of trust sound?

Trustworthy computing means things don't go wrong. It means that if things go wrong, your business won't be disrupted while things get fixed. It means that your data and your privacy are secure.

There is no trust. Things go wrong all the time. Patches that are intended to fix the things that go wrong, mess up things that weren't wrong in the first place. And few people actually believe that when Microsoft is scanning your computer, they are not going to read everything you want to keep hidden. They don't, but the impression is the only thing that counts. Security is all about trust. If the good guys don't build trust, the bad guys win. And the 'good' guys in this picture, have a long road ahead.

And while we wait, all we can do is cross our fingers and choose to update.



sumod_hajela@jasubhai.com



Sumod Hajela
Assistant Editor

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